



PHOTO BY MILIND SHELTE

and dropped from the team, only to defy all the odds at the 1983 World Cup that India won—the quintessential ‘comeback man’ of Indian sports.

It’s no surprise then that Mumbai-headquartered ICICI Bank chose to tap into this powerful story and invited Amarnath recently to have a chat with employees. In the fast-changing banking world,

1 ICICI BANK TOP ATTRIBUTES

- FAIR AND OBJECTIVE PROCESSES AND POLICIES
- GROWTH AND LEARNING OPPORTUNITIES
- JOB SECURITY AND STABILITY

◀ **SPORTING SPIRIT** T.K. Srirang, Group Chief Human Resources Officer, ICICI Bank, with colleagues

there are times when an employee feels overlooked, and wishes to reskill and upgrade. Amarnath’s journey serves as a compelling narrative of the triumph of will, grit, and determination.

In fact, this isn’t the first time that the bank has tapped into the sporting world. To emphasise the importance of teamwork, it invited former Indian hockey team captain Viren Rasquinha about two years ago to discuss how hockey—as it is played now—requires continuous adaptation, adjustment, and on-the-fly strategising. The bottom line of these HR exercises is to help employees excel as a team.

It’s central to MD and CEO Sandeep Bakhshi’s strategy of ‘One Bank, One Team’. Since Bakhshi joined the bank in October 2018, the bank’s HR policies have undergone a significant overhaul. In the process, it has moved away from an individual key performance indicators-driven model to a team-based approach.

It is one of only a few large organisations to have adopted such an approach. But it seems to be finding resonance elsewhere. In fact, the bank was pleasantly surprised this year when it got a call from a small bank in the UK inquiring about its ‘One Bank, One Team’ model. That bank, too, follows the

same HR practices.

With four to five years having passed since the system was adopted, it is proving highly effective. “It reinforces the fact that we are on the right track,” says T.K. Srirang, Group Chief Human Resources Officer of ICICI Bank. He took over as Joint Managing Director of ICICI Securities from May this year. “The bank has been growing across segments, indicating that working as a team yields far more value to all of us as an institution,” he says.

At the heart of the new system is the belief that every employee joins the bank to do their best, express themselves, and unleash their potential. The bank sees its role as supporting, enabling, and providing the right platform. As a result, its 141,000 employees do not require constant monitoring or individual targets. That approach has propelled it to the top of *BT-Tagg*’s The Best Companies to Work For in India list.

TEAM TARGETS

The bank is looking to move beyond traditional measures of productivity that originate from the manufacturing world. Effectively serving customers depends on understanding their specific needs and the segment they belong to. Financial services deal with unique customers, and tailoring services to meet individual needs can always be challenging. “Our focus is to ensure that our employees consistently uphold the values and ethos of the institution,” says Srirang.

One way to ensure that the bank feels that way is through its recruitment process. It is also vital because of the bank’s custom-